

Streetlit Discovery Acceptance Model (v3)

Purpose

Streetlit exists to help people pay closer attention to the places they move through every day.

The world is already full of stories, traces, and connections that are easy to overlook. Streetlit's purpose is not to catalog nearby places or overwhelm users with facts, but to surface discoveries that deepen their understanding of where they are and what they are seeing.

A discovery may be historical, cultural, architectural, social, or simply a new way of looking at something familiar. Whether dramatic or subtle, a successful discovery creates a meaningful shift in perception.

Before:

"I know this place exists."

After:

"I understand something about this place that I didn't notice before."

Core Principle

A discovery is not a place.

A discovery is a meaningful relationship between a place and a hidden story, context, detail, or perspective.

Streetlit should prioritize discoveries that reveal something a user would not likely know simply by looking at a place.

A discovery should explain more than the place itself. It should explain something about people, time, culture, or the surrounding environment.

The strongest discoveries make the familiar feel deeper.

Discovery Success Test

Before hearing the discovery:

“I know this place exists.”

After hearing the discovery:

“I know something meaningful about why this place matters, how it came to be, what happened here, what it reveals about the neighborhood, or how to see it differently.”

If the user’s understanding of the place is materially unchanged, the discovery should not auto-surface.

Discovery Tiers

Tier 1: Hidden Story (Highest Priority)

The place reveals a human, historical, cultural, architectural, or social story that is not immediately obvious.

Examples:

- A school whose design reflects public-health thinking during the Spanish Flu era.
- A former bank that later became a neighborhood gathering place.
- A building associated with an important local event.
- A location tied to a notable person or community story.
- A seemingly ordinary storefront connected to a larger historical event.

These discoveries should be strongly favored.

Tier 2: Visible Curiosity

The place is visually distinctive or architecturally notable, and Streetlit provides meaningful context that helps the user understand what they are seeing.

Examples:

- Unusual architectural style.
- Distinctive facade details.
- Visible remnants of a former use.
- A building whose appearance reflects a particular era, technology, or design philosophy.

The goal is not merely to identify visual features, but to explain why they matter.

Tier 3: Contextual Discovery

The place itself may not be remarkable, but it serves as a doorway into understanding the neighborhood, city, or historical period.

Examples:

- A commercial strip that reflects streetcar-suburb development.
- A building that illustrates postwar growth patterns.
- A neighborhood institution that helps explain local identity.
- An ordinary residential block that reveals how a neighborhood developed over time.
- Infrastructure that explains how people once moved through the city.

These discoveries are especially valuable in areas with fewer obvious landmarks.

Tier 3 discoveries are not a fallback category. They are a core feature of the product and may become the most common type of discovery in everyday neighborhoods.

Tier 4: Metadata (Not Auto-Surfaced)

Examples:

- School
- Bank
- Office building
- Store
- Place of worship
- Address
- Generic business description

Metadata may support a discovery, but metadata alone is not a discovery.

These places may remain available through manual exploration but should not be automatically narrated.

Discovery Patterns Streetlit Should Favor

The strongest discoveries often follow one or more of these patterns.

Hidden Past

A place once served a different purpose than it does today.

Examples:

- Former bank turned bar.
 - Warehouse converted into apartments.
 - Industrial site repurposed for modern use.
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Visible Remnants

Physical clues from an earlier era remain visible to attentive observers.

Examples:

- Ghost signs.
 - Former vault doors.
 - Streetcar tracks.
 - Architectural details from a previous use.
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Human Stories

The place reveals something about how people lived, worked, gathered, learned, celebrated, struggled, or adapted.

Examples:

- Schools.
 - Churches.
 - Neighborhood institutions.
 - Community gathering places.
 - Sites connected to social movements, labor, immigration, crime, activism, or civic life.
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Why This Place Looks Like This

The discovery explains the present-day physical environment.

Examples:

- Streetcar-suburb development.
 - Public-health-driven architecture.
 - Industrial growth patterns.
 - Postwar expansion.
 - Historic street layouts that still shape modern buildings.
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Hidden Layers

The discovery reveals something concealed beneath, behind, or within the visible city.

Examples:

- Subway infrastructure.
 - Hidden train cars.
 - Buried waterways.
 - Concealed architectural features.
 - Forgotten transportation systems.
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Unexpected Connections

The discovery links an ordinary place to a larger historical, cultural, or social story.

Examples:

- Local events connected to broader history.
 - Buildings tied to larger movements.
 - Neighborhood features reflecting citywide change.
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Auto-Surface Criteria

A place should auto-surface only when there is evidence that it can create a meaningful change in perception.

Questions to ask:

- Does this reveal something hidden?
- Does it provide meaningful historical, cultural, architectural, or social context?
- Does it help the user see the place differently?
- Does it teach the user something they likely would not know otherwise?

- Does it explain something about people, time, culture, or the surrounding environment?

A “yes” to at least one of these questions is generally required.

Progressive Understanding

Streetlit should help users build an increasingly rich understanding of a place over the course of a walk.

Discoveries should complement one another rather than repeatedly explain the same theme.

Once a major contextual idea has been established, subsequent discoveries should:

- Deepen it
- Provide a different perspective
- Introduce a new theme
- Connect it to another aspect of the neighborhood

They should not simply restate the same insight in slightly different language.

Example:

Acceptable sequence:

1. Dundee developed as a streetcar suburb.
2. This commercial strip emerged to serve that growing population.
3. This school reflects the neighborhood’s transition into a permanent residential community.

Unacceptable sequence:

1. Streetcar suburb.
 2. Streetcar suburb.
 3. Streetcar suburb.
 4. Streetcar suburb.
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Silence Is Acceptable

Streetlit should prefer silence over metadata, but should prefer modest genuine discoveries over silence.

If only metadata is available, the app should generally remain silent rather than narrate obvious facts.

Users may still choose to explore such places manually.

Discovery Philosophy

Streetlit is not trying to constantly amaze users.

A discovery may be profound, surprising, subtle, or quiet.

The standard is not:

“Did this blow my mind?”

The standard is:

“Did this help me notice or understand something I would otherwise have missed?”

The goal is not a constant stream of facts.

The goal is a richer awareness of place.

Hall of Shame

FedEx Office

Before:

FedEx Office.

After:

FedEx Office.

Result: Reject.

Dundee Bank

Before:

Bank.

After:

Bank.

Result: Reject.

Dundee Professional Building

Before:

Office building.

After:

Office building.

Result: Reject.

Generic School

Before:

School.

After:

School serving local students.

Result: Reject.

Hall of Fame

Hidden Infrastructure

1915 subway ventilation grates revealing the transit system beneath the street.

Result: Accept.

Hidden Past

Former speakeasy entrance hidden within an ordinary storefront.

Result: Accept.

Why This Place Looks Like This

The Oregon Diner's angled wall preserving the footprint of Stonehouse Lane.

Result: Accept.

Human Story

The Windermere's role in the evolution of tenant-rights protections.

Result: Accept.

Visible Curiosity

The McGraw-Hill Building's distinctive Art Deco design and terra-cotta facade.

Result: Accept.

Hidden Layer

A Pullman sleeper car concealed inside an otherwise ordinary office building.

Result: Accept.

Social History

Matthews-Palmer Playground's connection to the history of gangs and neighborhood change in Hell's Kitchen.

Result: Accept.

Ordinary Place, Extraordinary Story

The former 596 Club's role in the history of the Westies and the transformation of Hell's Kitchen.

Result: Accept.